



PANIC: Kolkata is shocked by the violence and the state's response

"incontrovertible that in recent times there have been violations of human rights on a mass scale in Nandigram. Any violation of human rights on such a scale is, like Godhra, a worse scar on the nation." A few days later, the Union Home Ministry issued a stern note to the state Government laying down norms of justice in Nandigram. Even Prime Minister Manmohan Singh said he was "saddened" by what had been happening in Nandigram.

Left Front Chairman Biman Bose has added to the crisis facing the state Government. In response to Manmohan's remark, he said, "The prime minister should behave like a prime minister." Later, when the high court issued a damning ruling against the state Government on the Nandigram issue, it was Bose who put his foot in his mouth by openly declaring, "The court has started deciding what the state should do and what it should not. What is the need for the executive or legislature if the court can decide everything?" On Wednesday, after the riots—which were partly

about Nandigram and partly about the continued presence of controversial Bangladesh author Tasleema Nasreen in Kolkata—he retorted, "If she is causing problems here, she should go." Shortly after, he retracted, saying, "I am sorry. I was tired. So much has happened today." Left Front supporters are increasingly showing signs of getting tired of backing Bose and Buddhadeb. Bose may be a trigger-happy leader but as head of the government, it is Buddhadeb whose image has suffered.

With every passing day, Buddhadeb finds himself alone. Another huge vote bank of the Left Front, the minorities have increasingly moved away during Buddhadeb's tenure as chief minister, the final burst coming with the show of violence in mostly minorities majority areas of Kolkata on Wednesday. Significantly, Nandigram is a Muslim dominated area. It was significant that the first attacks by lumpens masquerading as rebels with a cause were on local CP(M) offices. Obviously, the mass faith that

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